The Praise of the Seven Tathāgatas

Saptatathāgatastotra · Toh 1165 · Derge Tengyur

དེ་བཞིན་གཤེགས་པ་བདུན་གྱི་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Seven Tathāgatas, known in Sanskrit as the Saptatathāgatastotra and in Tibetan as Dezhin Shekpa Dün gyi Töpa, is a short hymn in verse honoring the seven buddhas of the past. Opening with homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī, it gives one verse of praise to each of the seven in turn, Vipaśyin, Śikhin, Viśvabhū, Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni, Kāśyapa, and Śākyamuni, celebrating their compassion, their splendor, and the teaching by which they free beings from the ocean of existence. An eighth verse honors Maitreya, the bodhisattva who now dwells in the Tuṣita heaven and is only a single birth away from awakening, and the poet then dedicates the merit of the praise so that all sentient beings may be freed from every fault. It is Toh 1165 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the collection of praises (stotra), and its colophon records that it was translated by the Indian preceptor Padmākaravarman together with the Tibetan translator Rinchen Zangpo.

In Sanskrit: sapta tathāgata stotraḥ
In Tibetan: The Praise of the Seven Tathāgatas

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

Guru of beings, honored in return by the world of gods and humans,
Who, radiant with compassion, teaches the liberation that benefits others,
Who has passed beyond the great flood of the three realms of existence and reached the state of bliss:
Homage to the Tathāgata Vipaśyin.

Seeing clearly that the world lies sunk
In this ocean of existence, which has no end and no far shore,
He nonetheless teaches the Dharma in order to help:
Homage to that Victor, Śikhin.

He who has a splendor surpassing the sun and moon,
And who, in the ways of his wisdom and his conduct as well,
Like the depths of the ocean, cannot be fathomed:
Homage to that Buddha, Viśvabhū.

He by whose fame, like the rays of the moon,
The whole face of the earth appears richly adorned,

And who is as wondrous as the udumbara flower:
Homage to the great Lord of Sages, Krakucchanda.

Stainless, ever acting to bring benefit,
And free of attachment, he whose stainless mind,
Radiating forth, utterly destroys the dense darkness:
Homage to that Kanakamuni, worshipped by the gods.

He whose blazing splendor, the color of a mass of refined gold,
Is greater than that of a thousand suns,
Who is bowed to by all people and has become supreme in the world,
He who bears the name Kāśyapa: homage to him.

As the many rays of the sun open a grove of lotuses,
With the many rays of his speech he awakens the world:
The Teacher Śākyamuni, who holds the lamp of compassion,
He who reveals nirvāṇa: homage to him.

He whose awakening is held back by only a single birth,
Who is called Maitreya and dwells in the heavenly abode of Tuṣita,
He who will become a Sugata (a buddha) upon the earth:
To him I always pay homage with faith.

Through my praise of the seven Victors of the past
And of the eighth, the bodhisattva who will come hereafter,
Whatever endless, immeasurable merit I have gained,
By that may sentient beings too be freed from every fault.

The Praise of the Seven Tathāgatas is complete.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Padmākaravarman and the chief editor-translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

- The fourth verse calls its buddha "Dispeller of Wrong Faith" rather than using the usual Tibetan form of Krakucchanda's name; since it stands fourth among the seven, between Viśvabhū and Kanakamuni, it is taken as Krakucchanda.

In the first verse, "honored in return" follows the Tibetan literally; it may simply render a Sanskrit word for "revered."

Two small copyist's slips are read in their evident sense: a stray syllable in the opening homage is disregarded, and a misspelling of the word for "people" in the verse to Kāśyapa is read as that word.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.